Basics of Study Management

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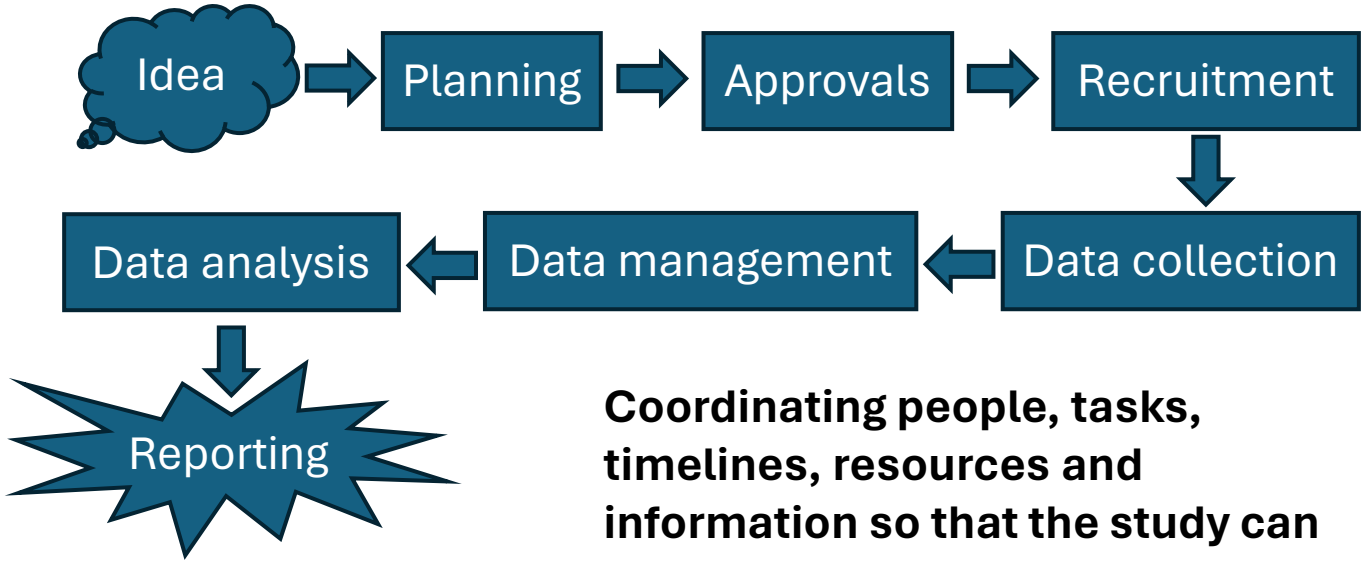


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What does study management mean?

You have a research question. What needs to happen before you can answer it?



Coordinating people, tasks, timelines, resources and information so that the study can actually happen.



Who does what?

Overall scientific responsibility, ethics permisology

Principal investigator

Day-to-day coordination

Study coordinator/ manager

Recruitment, data collection, documentation

Research assistants

Data entry, storage, quality check

Data manager



Clinical/professional partners

Clinical or practice expertise

Administrative support

Scheduling, materials, communication

Animal husbandry

Maintenance, compliance, inspection, loging

Statistician

Analysis plan / analysis

How do you want to manage communication?







In-person meetings
- For detailed discussions, planning, and decision-making
- Useful for building teamwork and resolving complex issues

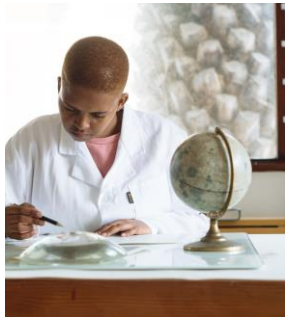
Digital platforms
- For daily updates, sharing information, coordinating tasks, and quick questions

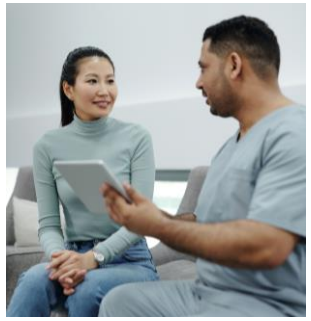
Phone / Emergency communication
- For urgent or time-sensitive situations
- Useful when an immediate response is needed

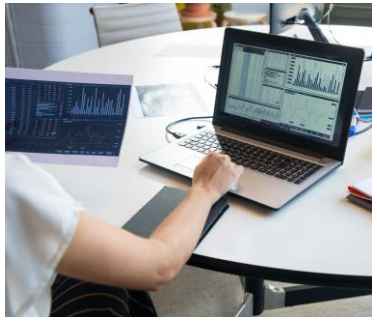
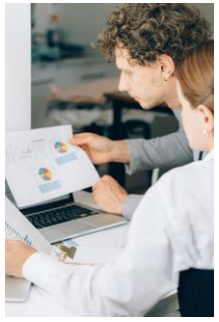
Written documentation & reports
- Used to record decisions, track progress, and ensure everyone has the same information
- Especially important for accountability and maintaining a clear record of the study

From tasks to a timeline

Time (months)	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
Protocol	■	■																						
Ethics/approvals	■	■																						
Recruitment			■	■	■																			
Data collection			■	■	■						▒	▒												
Data cleaning						■	■																	
Analysis								■	■	■	■		▒	▒	▒									
Reporting												■	■	■		▒	▒	▒						
Publication															■	■	■	■	■	▒	▒	▒	▒	▒







Gantt chart: visual timeline that shows what tasks need to be done, when they start and finish, and how they overlap, making it useful for planning and tracking projects.

Dependencies: relationships between tasks where one task must happen before another can start or finish.

Total estimated time = task durations + time for dependencies/delays + contingency (buffer)

What can go wrong?



Identify → Assign → Track → Communicate → Adapt

Group exercise: Build a study timeline

Study: A team wants to investigate whether a 6-week exercise programme improves sleep among university students.

Please identify:

A. What tasks need to happen?
B. Who is responsible?
C. What needs to happen first?
D. How long might each task take?
E. What could delay the study?



Professional-setting discussion

What would study management look like in your own workplace?

Possible prompts:

- Who coordinates research activities?
- Who communicates with participants?
- Who manages the data?
- Where do delays usually occur?
- What responsibilities are unclear?



Take-home messages



Good science still needs good coordination.

Everyone should know their responsibilities.

Build timelines around tasks and dependencies.

Anticipate problems before they happen.

Study management is continuous: plan, communicate, monitor and adapt.